

THE EARLY MODERN E

1420–1795

The course of world events always looks different in retrospect from the way that it appears at the time, but the contrast in perspective is rarely as extreme as in the Early Modern Era, which spanned the 15th, 16th, 17th, and 18th centuries. This period is often viewed today as the age during which Europe climbed toward world domination, but to Europeans living at the time it often seemed to be full of unprecedented disasters. The unity of Christendom was split by the Reformation, and sectarian conflict between Catholics and Protestants, combined with power struggles between competing royal dynasties, made Europe a place of frequent warfare—a continent tearing itself apart. Meanwhile, the Muslim armies of the Ottoman Empire threatened the heartland of Europe, seizing the Byzantine city of Constantinople and twice penetrating as far as Vienna.

Yet historical retrospect certainly recognizes changes underway that were to make European nations the founders of the modern world. The flowering of arts and ideas in the Renaissance meant that Europe ceased to be a cultural backwater. Printing and paper, both originally

invented in China, were used by Europeans to create mass-produced books that went on to revolutionize the dissemination of information. Gunpowder weapons, also invented by the Chinese, were deployed most effectively by European armies and navies. Above all, explorers and sailors from Europe's western seaboard established oceanic trade routes that laid the foundations for the first global economy.

The start of colonialism

The importance of Christopher Columbus's transatlantic voyage in 1492 cannot be exaggerated. It established a permanent link between two entire ecosystems that had evolved in isolation from each another for almost 10,000 years. The impact on the inhabitants of the Americas was catastrophic. Eurasian diseases and the infamous brutality of the Spanish conquistadors decimated the population. A remarkably small number of European invaders conquered the most sophisticated American states with startling ease, laying potentially the entire New World open to European exploitation and colonization.

However, the arrival of European sailors in Asia did not have the same dramatic